

Artist Prospecting System

Art Queens Gallery · The complete project, in plain English · 26 July 2026

1. What this project is for

Art Queens Gallery runs paid international exhibitions in Paris, New York and Milan. To fill them, we need to email professional female artists who fit our profile. This system's job is to find those artists and hand over a clean list of names with real, usable email addresses — so the outreach team can simply start writing.

That is the entire point. Everything else exists in service of that one deliverable.

2. What counts as “done” — the rule that governs everything

A row in the final list is only complete when it has two things: **the artist's name**, and **a verified email address that belongs to the artist personally**. Not the gallery's email. Not a magazine's. Not *info@somegallery.com*. The artist's own.

This sounds obvious, but it is the hardest part and the thing most tools get wrong. At one point the system reported **23 finished leads** — and 14 of them were secretly the same gallery's front-desk address, counted once for every artist on that gallery's page. The real number was 9.

That single distinction — *whose email is this actually?* — is what separates a list you can trust from a list that embarrasses you when you hit send. So the project does not measure success by “how many artists did we find.” It measures “how many complete, ready-to-email leads did we produce.”

3. Scope — what is in, what is out

In scope

- Starting from our list of **192 art-world organisations** — galleries, prizes, magazines, museums, art fairs.
- Visiting each one to find the artists it showcases.
- Filtering down to those matching our ideal profile: female, professional, right career stage, right countries.
- Hunting across the public web for each qualified artist's own email address.
- Verifying that the address is real and deliverable — without paying for a verification service.
- Sorting everyone into three buckets and exporting clean files.

Out of scope, deliberately

- **Sending the emails.** The system finds and verifies; a person writes and sends. This is a safety choice — we never want software firing thousands of emails in the gallery's name without a human in the loop.
- **Paid data services** such as LinkedIn scrapers or paid email finders. Everything comes from public sources.
- **Guessing at addresses.** If the system cannot confirm an email, it says so honestly rather than inventing *firstname@gmail.com*.

4. The three buckets every artist ends up in

Everyone the system examines lands in exactly one of these:

Bucket	What it means	The file you get
Completed lead	Fits the profile and has a verified personal email	COMPLETED_LEADS — the deliverable
Qualified, no email	Fits the profile, but no personal address could be found after exhausting every source	ENRICHMENT (not a must)
Rejected	Does not fit the profile — wrong gender, wrong career stage, not a real person	Held back, not exported as a lead

The middle bucket matters commercially. Those are good artists we might reach another way — an Instagram message, or the gallery as an intermediary. The system does not throw them away; it simply refuses to pretend it has their email. It currently holds **449 such records, 368 of them with a phone number.**

5. The steps, in order

Think of it as an assembly line. An artist's record moves from station to station:

- 1 **Input.** Read the Excel sheet of 192 organisations. Sort them by type, because a magazine, a gallery and a prize each list artists differently.
- 2 **Discovery.** Visit each organisation's website and collect the names of the artists it presents. Men appear here too — that is fine, they are filtered out at the next step.
- 3 **Extraction.** For each artist, pull the useful facts: country, career stage, exhibitions, statement, website, Instagram.
- 4 **Qualification.** Apply the ideal-profile rules. **This is the gate.** Anyone who fails stops here. Crucially, no email hunting happens until an artist passes — we do not spend money chasing contacts for people we would never email.
- 5 **Contact discovery.** For everyone who passed, search the public web for a personal email: their own site's contact page, their profiles, anywhere public. Several search methods run together and the results are pooled.
- 6 **Verification.** Check the address is real — correct format, the mail server genuinely exists, not a disposable domain. Score it high, medium or low confidence. And decide who owns it, rejecting anything that is actually a gallery or magazine address.
- 7 **Export.** Write the finished files.

An additional enrichment step gathers extra colour — exhibition history, press mentions, biography — for the completed leads, so outreach can be personal rather than generic.

6. What you actually do to get clean data

- 1 **Provide the input** — the Excel sheet of organisations. Already done. When you want more leads, you add more organisations to the sheet.
- 2 **Set the rules once.** The ideal-artist profile lives in a plain settings file: which countries count, what career stage, how strict the email-confidence threshold is. You tune this in one place and never touch code.
- 3 **Run it.** One command starts the pipeline. Because it saves its progress as it goes, if it stops halfway through 192 organisations it resumes rather than restarting — which matters, because a full run costs real money and takes hours.
- 4 **Collect the output.** Open the leads file. Every row carries the name, the verified email, a confidence score, and a link back to the exact page the email came from, so you can spot-check.
- 5 **Spot-check and send.** Click a few source links to confirm, then hand the file to outreach.

That is the whole workflow: you feed in organisations and rules, and you get back sorted files. The two folders that matter to a business owner are **config/**, where the rules live, and the output files, where the leads arrive. Everything else is machinery you never need to open.

7. Where the project stands right now

The permanent engine is built in careful phases, each tested and committed before the next begins. **All 11 foundation phases are now complete**, covered by 564 automated checks that run every time the code changes. This is the “build it right so it runs for years” track. What remains is the layer that connects that engine to live websites.

In parallel, we ran the whole process semi-manually to prove the approach end-to-end before investing further. It worked, and it has produced real leads:

117 completed leads — female artists with their own verified email addresses. 591 individual artists researched across 173 organisations. **22 leads are high confidence, 95 medium.** Medium means the address is real, resolves correctly, and was found on the artist's own page — usually a personal Gmail, which is normal for working artists. It does not mean the mailbox has been test-mailed.

The completion rate is honest. Roughly one in five researched artists becomes a completed lead. About half of all artists publish only their gallery's address, and the system correctly refuses to count those. Of 68 organisations tested, only **10** produced leads at all — the other 58 were structurally incapable of it, because their artists have no independent web presence to find an address on.

8. What happens after the 192 organisations are used up

The Excel sheet is not the project. It is the first tank of fuel. The system is built to keep running on new fuel indefinitely.

- **You add more organisations.** The sheet is designed to grow. When the first 192 are mined, drop in 200 more galleries, prizes and magazines and the same run picks them up. There are thousands of art-world organisations worldwide; we will not run out of sources.
- **The system remembers what it already found.** This is the important part. Every artist discovered goes into a growing database, so the second run does not repeat the first — it skips what we already have and works only the new ground. Over time this becomes a **compounding asset**: a qualified-artist database that grows more valuable with every run, not a list to be thrown away.
- **You re-run to refresh stale data.** Artists build new websites, add exhibitions and change addresses. Six months from now we can re-run over artists we already hold, to catch those who now have a public email but did not before — moving them out of “qualified, no email” and into completed leads without adding a single new organisation.

So the sheet running out is not an ending. It is the moment the project shifts from “prove it works” to “keep feeding it and harvest leads on a schedule.” Right now, about **900 artists inside the ten proven organisations are still unresearched**, and the expensive discovery work for them is already done and saved.

9. What you can do with this project — the bigger picture

- **A recurring lead machine.** Run it monthly. Each run adds fresh completed leads, so the outreach team always has a queue.
- **A qualified-artist database as a company asset.** Even artists without emails are valuable — we know they exist, that they fit, and where to find them. That is a directory of exactly the people this business exists to reach.
- **Campaign targeting.** Because every artist carries country, career stage and medium, the database can be sliced: “female sculptors in France at mid-career” for the Paris show specifically. One database, many campaigns.
- **Personalised outreach rather than spam.** The enrichment step means each lead arrives with real facts — a specific exhibition, a press mention — so emails reference the artist's actual work. That is the difference between a 1% and a 10% reply rate.
- **Swappable parts, so it does not age out.** The crawler, the AI and the email tools are plug-in modules. If a better AI arrives next year, or we add a paid data source later, we swap that one part rather than rebuilding. That is what protects the investment.

10. The numbers in full

The funnel, from the sheet to a sendable lead

Stage	Count	What happened here
Organisations in the sheet	192	The starting input
no website (Instagram only)	19	Cannot be searched; excluded
Organisations searched	173	Every page read, artist pages listed
Organisations with a real roster	68	Ten or more artists found; worth testing
Organisations that produced leads	10	The other 58 publish only a shared address
Artists researched individually	591	Each one traced through to a contact
confirmed real people	578	13 were page headings, not artists
holding a personal email	130	Passed the ownership test
Completed leads delivered	117	Female-confirmed and email verified as sendable

Read the last two rows together: of 130 artists whose own address we found, 117 survived the female-only check and the email quality bar. That is a 90% pass rate at the final gate, because most of the filtering already happened earlier.

Where the 117 leads came from

Organisation	Leads	Organisation	Leads
TERAVARNA	50	Art Market Experts	7
Rome Art Week	16	Circle Foundation for the Arts	7
International Guild of Realism	13	Miami Art Week	6
Visual Art Journal	10	Atlantic Gallery	6
World Illustration Awards	1	Culturally Arts Collective	1

What happened to the artists who did not become leads

Outcome	Artists	Meaning in plain English
No website of her own	163	Nothing to search; the trail ends
Website belonged to the organisation	139	Stopped early on purpose — saves two-thirds of the cost
Has a site, but no address on it	117	Publishes a contact form instead
Address found on her own site	82	The main source of leads
Address published on her profile	48	The cheapest kind of find
Address found but rejected	19	Proved to be an office or supplier mailbox
Her site could not be read	19	Site down, blocked, or too slow
Profile page could not be read	4	Broken or removed page

The second row is worth noting commercially. Recognising the organisation's own website early — rather than following it to a contact page and reading that too — is what let us research 591 artists on a budget that would otherwise have covered barely 300.

11. The scoring system — how an email earns its place

Every address found is scored from 0 to 100. The score is not a guess about whether the artist will reply; it measures **how confident we are that this address is real and belongs to her**. It starts from where the address was found, adds points for corroborating evidence, and subtracts for warning signs.

Test	Effect	Why it matters
Found on the artist's own contact page, or a direct mail link	+30	The strongest possible evidence of ownership
Found anywhere else	+10	Weaker — could be quoted or second-hand
Email domain matches the artist's own website	+25	<i>anna@annasmith.com</i> on <i>annasmith.com</i> is self-proving
The mail domain genuinely exists and accepts mail	+20	Rules out dead domains and typos
Correct format, and not a known misspelling	+10	Catches <i>gmial.com</i> and similar
A personal mailbox rather than a desk address	+10 / +5	<i>anna@</i> scores above <i>info@</i>
Disposable or misspelled domain	-20	A throwaway address is not a business contact
Free provider <i>and</i> not found on her own page	-20	A stray Gmail with no supporting source is weak

A free Gmail address is **not** penalised when it was published on the artist's own contact page. For individual artists that is completely normal — most working artists use Gmail rather than a custom domain. It only counts against the score when there is no solid source behind it.

The four bands, and which ones we send to

Band	Score	What it means	In this delivery
High	80–100	Address is on her own domain, or on her own contact page and fully corroborated	22 leads — exported
Medium	55–79	Real, resolving address found on her own page; usually a personal Gmail	95 leads — exported
Low	30–54	Weak or unsupported evidence of ownership	Withheld from the leads file
Reject	under 30	Almost certainly wrong, dead, or not hers	Discarded

Only High and Medium reach the leads file. Low and Reject are held back deliberately: a bounced email damages the sender reputation of the gallery's whole domain, which harms every future campaign, not just that one message. Across the 117 delivered leads the actual scores run from **70 to 95**, and 113 of the 117 also carry the artist's own website for cross-checking.

One limitation stated plainly: no address has been test-mailed. Doing that properly needs a paid verification service. Verification here means the format is right, the mail server genuinely exists, and the ownership evidence holds up — not that a message has been delivered. Some bounces should still be expected on a first send.

The other 449 records, and why they are kept

Group	Count	Why it is kept
Completed leads	117	The deliverable; also listed here with phone and website
Not confirmed female	194	Real artists with contact details, held back by the gender check
No email found	138	Fits the profile; reachable another way — Instagram, or via the gallery
Carrying a phone number	368	Enrichment only — a phone never makes a lead count as complete
Carrying the artist's own website	418	The best starting point for manual research

12. Handing the project to someone else

Short version: yes, this can be handed over — but only if the right things go with it, and the person is technical enough to run a program. Both halves of that deserve an honest answer.

What they need to receive

Handing over the folder alone is not quite enough. They need:

- 1 **The whole project folder** — the code, the configuration, the README.
- 2 **The keys file (.env) — the critical piece.** The system uses a web-crawling service and an AI service, both of which require paid account keys. Those keys are secret and are deliberately *not* stored in the code. Hand over the folder without explaining this and it will not run. That is by design: keys inside code is how companies leak credentials.
- 3 **The Excel input sheet.**

What they need to be able to do

- **Install it.** The README has the exact steps — install Python, create an environment, run one install command. It is copy-and-paste, but it assumes they can open a terminal.
- **Use their own service keys.** They sign up for the two services and paste their keys into the .env file. You could share yours instead, but then you pay for their runs.
- **Adjust the rules if needed** — edit one settings file in a text editor. It is plain, commented, English-like settings, with no programming involved.
- **Run one command and collect the files.**

The honest gap

The permanent engine is finished and tested, but the layer that plugs it into live websites is still being written. Until that is done, the leads are produced by a working set of operator-grade scripts run in sequence — the same ones that produced the 117 leads — rather than a single polished button. A capable technical person can run them today. An operator cannot, comfortably, yet.

When the remaining layer is complete, the handover becomes genuinely simple: install, paste keys, run one command, open the file.

The cleanest handover package

- 1 The project folder, **minus your secret keys.**
- 2 A short note: “sign up for the two services, put your keys in .env — instructions are in the README.”
- 3 The Excel sheet.
- 4 Point them at **README.md** first, and **ARCHITECTURE.md** if they want to understand why it is built the way it is.

The reason it hands over well at all is the discipline kept throughout: settings live in configuration files, secrets live outside the code, and there is a written source-of-truth document. A pile of clever scripts with keys hardcoded inside would be nearly impossible to pass on. This was built to survive changing hands.

13. Two decisions worth taking

- **Whether to pay for an email verification service.** This would turn most of the 95 medium-confidence leads into high confidence and reduce bounces on the first send.
- **Whether to prioritise finishing the connecting layer.** This is what turns “handoverable by an engineer” into “runnable by an operator,” and it is the strongest reason to keep building in the planned order.

One safety point worth repeating. The system deliberately does not send email. It finds and verifies; a person sends. Every address arrives with a link to the page it came from, so any lead can be checked in seconds before anyone writes to it.